

have USB-C Thunderbolt. One exception: if you need to daisy-chain monitors via MST (multi-stream), that often works only through actual DisplayPort or Thunderbolt/USB4, not HDMI.

- **SD card slot:** A must-have for photographers and videographers. There are two sizes: full-size SD and microSD. Full-size SD is much more useful if you use DSLR or mirrorless cameras (they mostly use SD cards). A built-in full SD slot (especially if it's UHS-II or UHS-III rated) lets you transfer photos quickly without an external reader. For example, the Dell XPS 15 and 16-inch MacBook Pro reintroduced SD card slots, which creators love. microSD slots are common on some thin ultrabooks and tablets – fine if your devices use microSD (drones, action cams, or you use it for phone storage transfer), but you can always use a microSD-to-SD adapter in a full slot, not vice versa. If you're not in the habit of using memory cards, this may not matter. But note, an SD slot can also be a handy way to expand storage on the cheap (pop a high-capacity microSD as semi-permanent extra storage for files, though speeds are lower than an internal SSD).
- **USB4/Thunderbolt docks and expansion:** If your laptop has limited ports (say just 2x USB-C), you can greatly expand it with a docking station. A Thunderbolt 4 dock can provide multiple USB-A's, additional display outputs, Ethernet, etc. via one cable. So, a minimalist-port laptop can become a desktop-like setup at your desk. Just ensure the laptop supports it (for instance, Apple MacBooks and many Windows ultrabooks do – you plug one TB4 cable and the dock charges the laptop and connects all peripherals). If you foresee this, allocate a budget for a good dock (~₹15k for a Thunderbolt dock from Dell/HP/Lenovo or brands like Caldigit).
- **Ethernet (RJ-45):** Wired networking ports are fading on slimmer laptops, but they're still found on many gaming laptops and business models (often with a fold-out jack design). If you do a lot of large file transfers on a local network, or just prefer the stability and low latency of wired internet (for gaming or video calls), having a built-in Ethernet is nice. If not, you can always use a cheap USB-C to Ethernet adapter or a dock. Gamers might want at least Gigabit Ethernet (almost all are gigabit now; a few high-end have 2.5GbE ports).
- **Audio jacks:** Surprisingly, a few recent ultrathin laptops have omitted the 3.5mm headphone jack (expecting you to use Bluetooth). Most still have it – and many users value the jack for universal compatibility with headphones, mics, conference room speakerphones, etc. If you care about wired audio, double-check it's there. If not, you'll need a USB-C audio dongle.
- **Other ports:** Some laptops have specialty ports like smart-card readers (for enterprise security), SIM card slots (for cellular 4G/5G WWAN capability), or proprietary docking connectors (common in older business models, less so now with USB-C universal docks). If you need 4G/5G connectivity, look for mention of WWAN or a SIM slot (and ensure the model supports the bands in India). This is more common

in business lines (ThinkPad X1, HP EliteBook, Dell Latitude options). It's a niche requirement, but invaluable if you're frequently without Wi-Fi.

In summary, list out what you plug in daily (or weekly) to your current machine. That will tell you what you need. It's better to have one or two extra ports than to find yourself scrambling for dongles. However, don't dismiss a great laptop just because it lacks a port – as long as it has the ability to expand (Thunderbolt/USB-C), you can adapt it. For instance, the Dell XPS 13 Plus has only 2 TB4 ports; it's super sleek, and with a tiny hub in your bag, you're covered when you need to plug more in. Just weigh the convenience vs. minimalism factor for your use-case.

6. Connectivity: Wi-Fi 7 and more

Wireless connectivity is another cornerstone – nobody wants a fast laptop that's slow online. The latest buzz is Wi-Fi 7 (802.11be). Let's break down what Wi-Fi 7 brings to the table and what you should consider regarding routers and network setup:



- **Wi-Fi 7 vs previous gen:** Wi-Fi 6 (2019) and 6E (2021) were the previous standards. Wi-Fi 7's headline features:

1. **320 MHz channel width:** This doubles the max channel size from 160 MHz in Wi-Fi 6/6E to 320 MHz (in the 6 GHz band). In simpler terms, the "pipe" for data is twice as wide, allowing much higher throughput if you have a clean, wide chunk of spectrum.
2. **4K-QAM modulation:** QAM is how data is packed into radio signals. Wi-Fi 6 used 1024-QAM (meaning 10 bits per symbol). Wi-Fi 7 jumps to 4096-QAM – 12 bits per symbol, which is about a 20% increase in theoretical throughput over Wi-Fi 6 at a given signal strength. This higher modulation needs a strong, clean signal (short range, minimal interference), but it squeezes more data into the air.
3. **Multi-Link Operation (MLO):** Perhaps the coolest feature – a Wi-Fi 7 device can connect to a router on multiple bands at once (e.g., 5 GHz and 6 GHz, or two channels within 5 GHz). This can increase throughput and reduce latency by using whatever path is best or